

Clients may experience physical complications during a tattoo session, with a range of possible causes. As a tattoo artist, acting quickly and correctly is what prevents a manageable situation from becoming a serious one. This guide sets out the steps to follow if complications arise during or after tattooing.

Allergic reaction — an immune system response to certain substances, which occurs after the body has been exposed to a foreign substance multiple times.

1. Stop tattooing immediately if signs of an allergic reaction appear.
2. Breathing difficulty, facial/throat swelling, or fast-spreading reaction — treat as anaphylaxis (section 2) and call 112.
3. Mild, localized reaction (redness, itching, no breathing issues) — remove the dye where possible and cover with a dry bandage.
4. Offer an antihistamine if the client has one, or refer to a doctor. Watch for 30–60 minutes, since mild reactions can escalate.

Anaphylactic shock — a severe, fast-developing allergic reaction affecting the whole body, which is life-threatening and requires emergency treatment.

Signs and symptoms of shock: **Redness in the face; Restlessness; Full pulse rate of 80-90; Rapid and deep breathing; Inadequate reaction.**

1. Call 112 immediately — say it's a suspected anaphylactic reaction.
2. If the client has their own EpiPen, ask if they can use it themselves. If not, only use it for them once instructed by the 112 operator.
3. Loosen or remove anything restricting breathing (collar, scarf).
4. Sit them up if breathing is difficult; lay them down with legs raised if dizzy or losing consciousness.
5. Give no food or drink — risk of choking if the throat is swelling.

6. Stay with them, monitor breathing and consciousness, and wait for the ambulance. They need to see a doctor even if symptoms improve.

Nausea or Loss of Consciousness (Fainting) — a brief loss of consciousness caused by a temporary drop in blood flow to the brain, often triggered by pain, stress, or sitting/standing still for too long.

1. Stop tattooing; have the client sit or lie down.
2. Lying down, raise their legs for ten minutes; sitting up, lower their head between their knees for about a minute unless it worsens nausea.
3. Give them fresh air.
4. Once steadier, offer a sugary drink or snack (dextrose, apple juice).
5. If briefly unconscious, let them rest for ten minutes before standing. Unconscious for over a minute or not fully recovering — call 112.
6. Watch them closely afterward, especially on stairs.

Skin inflammation — a localized reaction in the skin, causing redness, swelling, heat, or irritation at or around the tattooed area.

1. Stop the procedure.
2. Clean and treat the area with antiseptic and cover with a dry bandage.
3. Offer a painkiller if needed, or refer the client to a doctor if it doesn't settle or looks like it's spreading.

Excessive bleeding — bleeding from the tattooed area that is heavier or longer-lasting than what's normally expected during the procedure.

1. Stop the procedure.
2. Apply firm pressure with a clean dressing and elevate the affected limb above heart level if possible.
3. If bleeding doesn't stop after a few minutes of steady pressure, call for emergency medical assistance.

